THE 3PM RESET — A COGNITIVE LOAD JOURNAL

A short worksheet for the moments your brain feels full. Work through it in order — each step builds on the last, from noticing what happened to deciding what you'll do differently.

1

Notice

What's one moment from today that felt heavier than it should have?

2

Name what was really going on

Was it the task itself that was hard — or something around it (interruptions, unclear asks, too many things at once)? Be specific.

3

Reflect

Looking back, what would have made that moment lighter — even slightly?

4

Commit to one change

Turn your reflection into a plan using an if-then statement — naming a specific trigger and exactly what you'll do when it happens. Research on implementation intentions (Gollwitzer, 1999) shows this simple structure makes people significantly more likely to follow through, because the decision is already made before the moment arrives.

Also name the type of load you identified in Step 2 (intrinsic, extraneous, or germane). You can pick one of the four strategies from Lesson 3, or choose something else entirely — whatever you genuinely think would help most.

If _____ ,

then I will _____

_____ .

The type of load this addresses: _____

Come back to this page whenever a day feels like this again — the goal isn't to fill it out perfectly, just honestly.

From the course "Cognitive Load at Work: Why Your Brain Feels Full by 3PM" — Costiana Cojocaru